

this area. Harris, the photographer, also admits that vendors rarely put their prices on their websites, forcing couples to inquire privately about the costs. There's very little transparency in the wedding industry. In fact, Harris said the many wedding business blogs he read when he was starting his own business all advised vendors to steer away from talking explicitly about price for as long as possible. (Shady!) He said the best thing to do is to insist on hearing a price range before any other sales pitch. "We vendors might hate it," he said in the video, "but it's the fair thing to do."

So why are so many people willing to subject themselves to an exploitative industry? The answer I got most from my friends is, "It's fun!" (Also: "You're a buzzkill, Gaby, and you always have been!") The fact is, people love their own weddings. They love other people's weddings. They love watching TV shows and movies about weddings. Society values weddings, and until that stops being the case, people will continue to want to spend on an event that is so culturally important.

If you ask me, a lot of it comes down to expensive emotional blackmail. Think of any photo you've ever seen of your great-great grandmother. It was almost certainly a wedding photo. That's the photo your ancestors will share of you—on a microchip implanted in their brains. Weddings are visual. Wedding dresses are a massive industry because of the importance our culture puts on finding the perfect dress. (For example, what are your ancestors wearing in those photos? Why does a mother cry when she sees her daughter coming out of the dressing room in that angelic white gown?)

In 2012, new bride Caitlin Kenney created a video for *Slate* magazine about the cost of wedding dresses. One of the points she made was that just because something is sold as a wedding dress, that doesn't mean it's quality. Her dress, for example, was made primarily of polyester, the same fabric as a T-shirt in an H&M that goes for thirteen bucks. When she went to an appraiser after the wedding, she guessed the fabric altogether cost \$500. Kenney reveals that her dress cost her \$2,730.

So what's that extra \$2,230 for? Emotion? The feeling of having a fancy-ass wedding dress to take photos in and so that your friends and family will tell you you look incredible? "It's not just a dress you're paying for. It's the message